HARVARD MEDICAL SCHOOL | Master of Science in Clinical Research

SMCR Capstone Progress Report 2: Systematic Review Protocol Readiness

***Meeting deadline**:* Friday, November 6, 2026

Next milestone: Systematic Review Protocol Submission - Monday, November 23, 2026

Purpose: To determine whether the student has developed a complete, methodologically rigorous, and reproducible systematic review protocol that is ready for formal submission.

Instructions: The student should complete Sections A-C and submit this report to the advisor at least 24 hours before the meeting. The advisor should complete Section D following the meeting.

……

A. Student and Project Information

Student:

Program Advisor:

Date of Meeting:

Working Capstone Title:

_____
_____
_____

Proposed Research Question(s):

_____
_____
_____

Protocol registration status: [ ] Not started [ ] Registration requirements reviewed [ ] Registration draft prepared [ ] Submitted for registration [ ] Registered

……

B. Protocol Development Checklist

Indicate the status of each protocol component.

Protocol Component	Complete	In Progress	Not Started	Not Applicable
Final research question and objectives	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Complete Introduction	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Clinical rationale and evidence gap	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Eligibility criteria	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Information sources and databases	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Reproducible draft search strategy	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Study selection and screening procedures	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Data extraction variables and procedures	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Risk-of-bias assessment plan	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]

Primary and secondary outcomes	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Effect measures	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Evidence-synthesis or meta-analysis plan	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Heterogeneity assessment	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Subgroup analyses, if applicable	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Sensitivity analyses, if applicable	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Reporting-bias assessment, if applicable	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Certainty-of-evidence assessment, if applicable	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
PRISMA-P checklist	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
Protocol registration plan	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]
References and appendices	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]

……

C. Student Pre-Meeting Progress Report

1. Progress since approval of the research question

Summarize the work completed since Progress Meeting 1, including any important changes to the research question, scope, population, intervention or exposure, comparator, outcomes, or eligible study designs.

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

2. Current barriers or concerns

Identify any issue that could delay the November 23 protocol submission.

[ ] Search strategy requires further development
[ ] Eligibility criteria remain unclear
[ ] Outcomes are not fully defined
[ ] Second reviewer has not been identified
[ ] Statistical support is needed
[ ] Software or database access is needed
[ ] Advisor decisions are pending
[ ] Writing is behind schedule
[ ] Other: _____

Explanation:

_____
_____

3. Guidance needed from the advisor

List the specific methodological or scientific decisions that must be resolved during this meeting.

_____

_____

_____

……

D. Advisor Assessment and Scoring

Score each criterion using the following scale:

- **4: Fully meets expectations:** Complete, rigorous, and ready to proceed.
- **3: Mostly meets expectations:** Adequate; minor revisions are needed.
- **2: Developing:** Partially complete; substantive revisions are needed.
- **1: Limited progress:** Major deficiencies require immediate attention.
- **0: No evidence:** Not submitted or not addressed.

Assessment Criterion	Advisor Score	Advisor Comments
Introduction clearly establishes the clinical problem, evidence gap, rationale, and objectives	___ / 4	
Eligibility criteria and outcomes are explicit, justified, and reproducible	___ / 4	
Search strategy and study-selection procedures are comprehensive and reproducible	___ / 4	
Data extraction, risk-of-bias assessment, and synthesis plan are methodologically appropriate	___ / 4	
Protocol is sufficiently complete for submission by November 23	___ / 4	
Total Score	**___ / 20**	

Advisor's Overall Progress Determination

[ ] **Green – On track:** The project is appropriately scoped, and the student is prepared for the next milestone.

[ ] **Yellow – Support required:** Correctable deficiencies remain. Specific actions and a follow-up date are required.

[ ] **Red – At risk:** The question is not yet feasible or sufficiently developed. A formal remediation plan and program notification are required.

Overall advisor comments:

_____

_____

_____